

Heart of Darkness

A rare glimpse into the sins and secrets of urban modernity in the Kolkata of the '70s

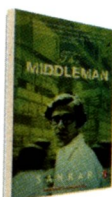
By Damayanti Datta

If a birthday is an occasion for rebirth, Somnath Banerjee awakes to a new life of corruption on his 25th birthday. At one time, the dirty-smelly Chitpur Road—packed with a parading throng of humanity pressing in on all sides—might have inspired him to pen a few lines on the human jungle that is Kolkata. To be read out to his muse, Tapati, the very next day, of course. But poetry seems to have left him forever. His ears go red as he thinks about the job in hand: he has to hook a prostitute for a client. He looks up at the sky and prays for torrential rain to drown out his past, who he was.

It's the story of a city at war with itself: where idealistic young men offer up prostitutes for business favours; happy-go-lucky people lose their sanity in a frenzy of job searching and family pressure; the secret goings-on of wives and mothers bathe genteel neighbourhoods in a gray malaise; lovers beg for a chance in a cynical, disbelieving world, where no one has the right to be mediocre without the jingle of money in the pocket. It's the Kolkata of the 1970s. A time and place that now exist in literature, art and memories for the existential despair that whistled through the cracks of the city.

It was the decade of strikes and unemployment, Maoist militancy, electricity shortage and piles of rubbish rotting on the street. The crisis of economy was at once a crisis in ideology. *Jana Aranya*, written by Sankar and captured on celluloid by Satyajit Ray in 1975, is a classic witness to the bewildered and ambiguous lives of those navigating that world full of contradiction, disillusionment and desperation. Newly translated by Arunava Sinha, *The Middleman*, offers a rare glimpse into the deepest secrets and darkest sins of urban modernity.

The curtain goes up on Somnath, the son of an upright civil servant and brother to two bright IIT engineers, who failed to plumb the job market with his mediocre degrees. The tone darkens and horrors pile up as Somnath's friend, Sukumar, caught between the reality of not finding a job and feeding hungry mouths at home, loses his mind. Focusing on the fate of young job hopefuls, the book takes us into homes, neighbourhoods, offices and hotels to give shape and texture to a milieu on a slide. There's no redemption at the end of the story: Somnath does get his contract, but at the cost of his integrity. A particularly poignant read in these anxious times, when mastering one's destiny often ends up being remarkably costly. ■



THE MIDDLEMAN
by SANKAR
Translated by
ARUNAVA SINHA
Penguin
Price: Rs 200
Pages: 192

TOP 10

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1. Paths of Glory
Jeffrey Archer, Macmillan
2. The Winner Stands Alone
Paulo Coelho, HarperCollins
3. The White Tiger
Aravind Adiga, HarperCollins
4. The Associate
John Grisham, Arrow
5. Angels & Demons
Dan Brown, Pocket Books

NON-FICTION

1. Don't Lose Your Mind, Lose Your Weight
Rujuta Diwekar, Random House
2. A Better India A Better World
N.R. Narayana Murthy, Allen Lane
3. Stay Hungry Stay Foolish
Rashmi Bansal, CIE, IIM-Ahmedabad
4. Outliers: The Story of Success
Malcolm Gladwell, Allen Lane
5. Imagining India: Ideas for the New Century
Nandan Nilekani, Allen Lane

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6. My Friend Sancho
Amit Varma, Hachette India
9. Slumdog Millionaire
Vikas Swarup, Black Swan
11. If It is Sweet
Mridula Koshy, Tranquebar Press

NON-FICTION

6. BPO-Sutra: True Stories from Inside India's BPOs & Call Centres
Sudhindra Mokhasi, Rupa
7. India and the Global Financial Crisis
Y.V. Reddy, Orient Blackswan
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